

The Discourse about Vipassī Buddha

Vipassīsutta (SN 12.4)

Sāvatthiyaṃ viharati ...pe...

“vipassissa, bhikkhave, bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa pubbeva sambodhā anabhisambuddhassa bodhisattasseva sato etadahosi: ‘kicchaṃ vatāyaṃ loko āpanno jāyati ca jīyati ca mīyati ca cavati ca upapajjati ca. Atha ca paṇimassa dukkhassa nissaraṇaṃ nappajānāti jarāmaraṇassa. Kudāssu nāma imassa dukkhassa nissaraṇaṃ paññāyissati jarāmaraṇassā’ti?

Staying near Sāvatthī... and so on...

“Before his full awakening, monks, when Vipassī—the Blessed One, the fully liberated one (*arahant*), the fully self-awakened one (*sammāsambuddha*)—was still an unawakened being destined for awakening (*bodhisatta*), this occurred to him: ‘Alas, this world has fallen into distress! It is born, it decays, it dies, it passes away, and it is reborn. Yet it does not know the escape from this suffering (*dukkha*), from decay and death. When indeed will an escape from this suffering, from decay and death, be discerned?’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho sati jarāmaraṇaṃ hoti, kiṃpaccayā jarāmaraṇaṃ’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘jātiyā kho sati jarāmaraṇaṃ hoti, jātipaccayā jarāmaraṇaṃ’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what exists does decay and death occur? What is the condition for decay and death?’ Then, monks, through wise attention (*yoniso manasikāra*), there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization (*abhisamayo*) of wisdom (*paññā*): ‘When birth exists, decay and death occur; with birth as condition, decay and death arise.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho sati jāti hoti, kiṃpaccayā jāti’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘bhava kho sati jāti hoti, bhavapaccayā jāti’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what exists does birth occur? What is the condition for birth?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When becoming exists, birth occurs; with becoming as condition, birth arises.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho sati bhavo hoti, kiṃpaccayā bhavo’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘upādāne kho sati bhavo hoti, upādānapaccayā bhavo’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what exists does becoming occur? What is the condition for becoming?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When clinging exists, becoming occurs; with clinging as condition, becoming arises.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho sati upādānaṃ hoti, kiṃpaccayā upādānaṃ’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘taṇhāya kho sati upādānaṃ hoti, taṇhāpaccayā upādānaṃ’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what exists does clinging occur? What is the condition for clinging?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When craving exists, clinging occurs; with craving as condition, clinging arises.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho sati taṇhā hoti, kiṃpaccayā taṇhā’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘vedanāya kho sati taṇhā hoti, vedanāpaccayā taṇhā’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what exists does craving occur? What is the condition for craving?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When sensations exist, craving occurs; with sensations as condition, craving arises.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho sati vedanā hoti, kiṃpaccayā vedanā’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘phasse kho sati vedanā hoti, phassapaccayā vedanā’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what exists do sensations occur? What is the condition for sensations?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When contact exists, sensations arise; with contact as condition, sensations arise.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho sati phasso hoti, kiṃpaccayā phasso’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso

manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘saḷāyatane kho sati phasso hoti, saḷāyatanapaccayā phasso’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what exists does contact occur? What is the condition for contact?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When the six sense doors exist, contact occurs; with the six sense doors as condition, contact arises.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho sati saḷāyatanaṃ hoti, kiṃpaccayā saḷāyatanaṃ’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘nāmarūpe kho sati saḷāyatanaṃ hoti, nāmarūpapaccayā saḷāyatanaṃ’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what exists do the six sense doors occur? What is the condition for the six sense doors?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When mind-and-matter exists, the six sense doors arise; with mind-and-matter as condition, the six sense doors arise.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho sati nāmarūpaṃ hoti, kiṃpaccayā nāmarūpaṃ’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘viññāṇe kho sati nāmarūpaṃ hoti, viññāṇapaccayā nāmarūpaṃ’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what exists does mind-and-matter occur? What is the condition for mind-and-matter?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When consciousness exists, mind-and-matter arises; with consciousness as condition, mind-and-matter arises.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho sati viññāṇaṃ hoti, kiṃpaccayā viññāṇaṃ’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘saṅkhāresu kho sati viññāṇaṃ hoti, saṅkhārapaccayā viññāṇaṃ’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what exists does consciousness occur? What is the condition for consciousness?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When mental conditioning exists, consciousness arises; with mental conditioning as condition, consciousness arises.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho sati saṅkhārā honti, kiṃpaccayā saṅkhārā’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘avijjāya kho sati saṅkhārā honti, avijjāpaccayā saṅkhārā’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what exists does mental conditioning occur? What is the condition for mental conditioning?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When ignorance exists, mental conditioning arises; with ignorance as condition, mental conditioning arises.’

Iti hidaṃ avijjāpaccayā saṅkhārā;

saṅkhārapaccayā viññāṇaṃ ...pe... evametassa kevalassa dukkhakkhandhassa samudayo hoti. ‘Samudayo, samudayo’ti kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa pubbe ananussutesu dhammesu cakkhuṃ udapādi, ñāṇaṃ udapādi, paññā udapādi, vijjā udapādi, āloko udapādi.

Thus, with ignorance as condition, mental conditioning arises; with mental conditioning as condition, consciousness arises... and so on... Thus is the origin of this entire mass of suffering. ‘Origin, origin!’—thus, monks, regarding things unheard before, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the eye, knowledge, wisdom, true learning, and light.

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho asati jarāmaṇaṃ na hoti, kissa nirodhā jarāmaṇanirodho’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘jātiyā kho asati jarāmaṇaṃ na hoti, jātinirodhā jarāmaṇanirodho’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what does not exist does decay and death not occur? With the cessation of what does the cessation of decay and death occur?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When birth does not exist, decay and death do not occur; with the cessation of birth comes the cessation of decay and death.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho asati jāti na hoti, kissa nirodhā jātinirodho’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘bhavo kho asati jāti na hoti, bhavanirodhā jātinirodho’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what does not exist does birth not occur? With the cessation of what does the cessation of birth occur?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When becoming does not exist, birth does not occur; with the cessation of becoming comes the cessation of birth.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho asati bhavo na hoti, kissa nirodhā bhavanirodho’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘upādāne kho asati bhavo na hoti, upādānanirodhā bhavanirodho’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what does not exist does becoming not occur? With the cessation of what does the cessation of becoming occur?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When clinging does not exist, becoming does not occur; with the cessation of clinging comes the cessation of becoming.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho asati upādānaṃ na hoti, kissa nirodhā upādānanirodho’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘taṇhāya kho asati upādānaṃ na hoti, taṇhānirodhā upādānanirodho’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what does not exist does clinging not occur? With the cessation of what does the cessation of clinging occur?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When craving does not exist, clinging does not occur; with the cessation of craving comes the cessation of clinging.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho asati taṇhā na hoti, kissa nirodhā taṇhānirodho’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘vedanāya kho asati taṇhā na hoti, vedanānirodhā taṇhānirodho’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what does not exist does craving not occur? With the cessation of what does the cessation of craving occur?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When sensations do not exist, craving does not occur; with the cessation of sensations comes the cessation of craving.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho asati vedanā na hoti, kissa nirodhā vedanānirodho’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘phasse kho asati vedanā na hoti, phassanirodhā vedanānirodho’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what does not exist do sensations not occur? With the cessation of what does the cessation of sensations occur?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When contact does not exist, sensations do not occur; with the cessation of contact comes the cessation of sensations.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho asati phasso na hoti, kissa nirodhā phassanirodho’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa

bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘saḷāyatane kho asati phasso na hoti, saḷāyatananirodhā phassanirodho’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what does not exist does contact not occur? With the cessation of what does the cessation of contact occur?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When the six sense doors do not exist, contact does not occur; with the cessation of the six sense doors comes the cessation of contact.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho asati saḷāyatanaṃ na hoti, kissa nirodhā saḷāyatananirodho’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘nāmarūpe kho asati saḷāyatanaṃ na hoti, nāmarūpanirodhā saḷāyatananirodho’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what does not exist do the six sense doors not occur? With the cessation of what does the cessation of the six sense doors occur?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When mind-and-matter does not exist, the six sense doors do not occur; with the cessation of mind-and-matter comes the cessation of the six sense doors.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho asati nāmarūpaṃ na hoti, kissa nirodhā nāmarūpanirodho’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘viññāṇe kho asati nāmarūpaṃ na hoti, viññāṇanirodhā nāmarūpanirodho’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what does not exist does mind-and-matter not occur? With the cessation of what does the cessation of mind-and-matter occur?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When consciousness does not exist, mind-and-matter does not occur; with the cessation of consciousness comes the cessation of mind-and-matter.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho asati viññāṇaṃ na hoti, kissa nirodhā viññāṇanirodho’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘saṅkhāresu kho asati viññāṇaṃ na hoti, saṅkhāranirodhā viññāṇanirodho’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what does not exist does consciousness not occur? With the cessation of what does the cessation of consciousness occur?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When mental conditioning does not exist, consciousness does not occur; with the cessation of mental conditioning comes the cessation of consciousness.’

Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa etadahosi: ‘kimhi nu kho asati saṅkhārā na honti, kissa nirodhā saṅkhāranirodho’ti? Atha kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa yoniso manasikārā ahu paññāya abhisamayo: ‘avijjāya kho asati saṅkhārā na honti, avijjānirodhā saṅkhāranirodho’ti.

Then, monks, this occurred to the Bodhisatta Vipassī: ‘When what does not exist does mental conditioning not occur? With the cessation of what does the cessation of mental conditioning occur?’ Then, monks, through wise attention, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the realization of wisdom: ‘When ignorance does not exist, mental conditioning does not occur; with the cessation of ignorance comes the cessation of mental conditioning.’

Iti hidam avijjānirodhā saṅkhāranirodho; saṅkhāranirodhā viññāṇanirodho ...pe... evametassa kevalassa dukkhakkhandhassa nirodho hotīti. ‘Nirodho, nirodho’ti kho, bhikkhave, vipassissa bodhisattassa pubbe ananussutesu dhammesu cakkhum udapādi, ñāṇam udapādi, paññā udapādi, vijjā udapādi, āloko udapādī’ti.

Thus, with the cessation of ignorance comes the cessation of mental conditioning; with the cessation of mental conditioning comes the cessation of consciousness... and so on... Thus is the cessation of this entire mass of suffering. ‘Cessation, cessation!’—thus, monks, regarding things unheard before, there arose in the Bodhisatta Vipassī the eye, knowledge, wisdom, true learning, and light.”

Catuttham.

(Fourth)

(Sattannampi buddhānaṃ evaṃ vitthāretabbo.)

(This should be expanded in the same way for all seven Buddhas.)

Glossary

Pāli (IAST)	Target transliteration	Target gloss	First-chapter occurrence	Goenka-tradition usage
bodhisatta	bodhisatta	a being destined for awakening	The Discourse about Vipassī Buddha	An unawakened being striving for full liberation and awakening.

Pāli (IAST)	Target transliteration	Target gloss	First-chapter occurrence	Goenka-tradition usage
arahant	arahant	fully liberated one	The Discourse about Vipassī Buddha	One who has destroyed all defilements and achieved final liberation.
sammāsambuddha	sammāsambuddha	fully self-awakened one	The Discourse about Vipassī Buddha	A Buddha who discovers the path to liberation by himself and teaches it to others.
yoniso manasikāra	yoniso manasikāra	wise attention	The Discourse about Vipassī Buddha	Thorough or root-level attention, a critical meditative factor.
abhisamayo	abhisamayo	realization	The Discourse about Vipassī Buddha	Direct, penetrative realization or breakthrough of wisdom.
avijjā	avijjā	ignorance	The Discourse on Analysis	Lack of experiential understanding of the Four Noble Truths.
saṅkhāra	saṅkhāra	mental conditioning	The Discourse on Analysis	Mental reactions and conditioning that drive rebirth and suffering.
viññāṇa	viññāṇa	consciousness	The Discourse on Analysis	The cognitive aspect of the mind that notes

Pāli (IAST)	Target transliteration	Target gloss	First-chapter occurrence	Goenka-tradition usage
				the presence of an object.
nāmarūpa	nāmarūpa	mind-and-matter	The Discourse on Analysis	The interactive combination of mental and physical components of existence.
saḷāyatana	saḷāyatana	six sense doors	The Discourse on Analysis	The six internal sense doors.
phassa	phassa	contact	The Discourse on Analysis	The meeting of sense door, sense object, and consciousness.
vedanā	vedanā	sensations	The Discourse on Analysis	The somatic experience of physical sensations on the body.
taṇhā	taṇhā	craving	The Discourse on Analysis	The reaction of liking/wanting that arises due to sensations.
upādāna	upādāna	clinging	The Discourse on Analysis	Intense attachment or grasping that grows out of craving.
bhava	bhava	becoming	The Discourse on Analysis	The process of active existence and accumulation of karmic force.

Pāli (IAST)	Target transliteration	Target gloss	First-chapter occurrence	Goenka-tradition usage
jāti	jāti	birth	The Discourse on Analysis	Rebirth or arising of new states of existence.
jarāmarāṇa	jarāmarāṇa	decay and death	The Discourse on Analysis	The inevitable disintegration and end of conditioned states.

Translator Notes

1. **Intimate Teacher-to-Student Voice:** The English translation maintains a direct and experiential tone, matching Goenkaji's spoken style.
2. **Breakthrough of Wisdom (paññāya abhisamayo):** Rendered as "realization of wisdom" to emphasize direct, personal realization rather than conceptual knowledge.
3. **Arises/Ceases in Chain Inquiries:** Maintained active verbs ("arises", "arise") throughout the Bodhisatta's analytical inquiry to capture the progressive meditative reflection.
4. **Eye, Knowledge, Wisdom, True Learning, and Light (cakkhum, ñāṇam, paññā, vijjā, āloko):** Preserved as a rhythmic progression representing the direct experience of awakening, matching Goenkaji's discourse register.